Amir Dost Mohammad resolved to wage jihad,
And to mint coins – May God grant him victory.

After his enthronement, Amir Dost Mohammad decided to fulfil the jihad. He left Kabul for Peshawar with an army made up of 60,000 men – royal horse and foot as well as irregular tribal forces.[38]

The declaration of jihad against the Sikhs brought with it a useful legitimisation of Dost Mohammad's seizure of power. He had never dared to claim the Sadozai title of shah, and up to this point his only legitimacy lay in the reality of his power and his reputation for justice. But he could now justify his rule by appeal to a higher Qur'anic authority, and the fulfilment of his duty as a good Muslim to wage holy war against the infidel and so – in theory – usher in a millennial Islamic Golden Age of purity and godliness. At the same time Dost Mohammad used the leadership of the jihad as a way to claim leadership of all the Afghan peoples, writing to the Governor General, 'these people are tribes of my nation, and their protection & support is an obligation as well as a duty . . . Reflect & consider if the Afghans can quietly submit to be injured and oppressed without resisting? As long as I retain life in my body, I can neither separate myself from my nation nor the nation from me.'[39]

Dost Mohammad made a first abortive attempt on Peshawar later that month, gathering a motley horde of jihadis – 'savages from the remotest mountains', according to Josiah Harlan, 'many of them giants in form and strength, promiscuously armed with sword and shield, bows and arrows, matchlocks, rifles, spears and blunderbusses, prepared to slay, plunder and destroy, for the sake of God and the Prophet, the unenlightened infidels of the Punjab'. In the event, the rabble were no match for the beautifully drilled and disciplined troops of the Khalsa and succeeded in doing little except provoking a massacre of the Muslim citizens of Peshawar by an angry Sikh soldiery. But the raid also allowed Dost Mohammad quietly to annex the Afghan provinces of Wardak and Ghazni which separated Kabul from the Khyber and the Sikh border; he had now increased his revenues five times over since first seizing control over the country immediately around Kabul eleven years earlier, and had become unquestionably the most powerful ruler in the country.

At the end of February 1837, the Amir opened hostilities against the Sikhs for the second time. 'Your occupation of Jamrud on the frontier of the